The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

America began a **blockade** of ships using Iranian ports and coastal areas. Donald Trump warned that any Iranian "fast attack" boats would be "immediately ELIMINATED" if they approached American military vessels. Ships arriving at or leaving from non-Iranian ports will be left alone, the Pentagon said earlier. By preventing Iranian oil exports, America may be hoping to force its regime back to the negotiating table in a weakened position.

In his first press conference after winning **Hungary's** parliamentary election, **Peter Magyar** pledged closer ties with the EU. He said his government would stop blocking the EU's planned €90bn ($105bn) loan to Ukraine. Earlier Viktor Orban, Hungary's prime minister since 2010, conceded defeat to Mr Magyar, whose centre-right Tisza party won a two-thirds majority—enough to amend Hungary's constitution.

Goldman Sachs reported a 14% year-on-year increase in net revenue, to $17bn, and a 19% rise in net profit, to $5.6bn, in the first quarter. Its markets division enjoyed higher investment-banking fees and record levels of equities trading, spurred by market volatility caused by the Iran war. However, fixed-income

revenues declined by 10%. The bank's share price fell in pre-market trading.

American **housing sales** fell to their lowest level since June last year, with 1% fewer existing homes sold in March, year on year, according to the National Association of Realtors. The NAR blamed low consumer confidence and a soft labour market. It cut its forecasted growth in sales for the year from 14% to 4%, to reflect limited housing supply and rising mortgage rates.

Over 1,000 writers, actors and directors signed an open letter opposing **Paramount Skydance's** deal to buy Warner Bros Discovery. Signatories warned that the resulting media colossus would lead to fewer jobs, fewer films and less choice for audiences. David Ellison, Paramount's boss, has pledged to invest in the Hollywood studios and release at least 30 films each year.

Audi, a German carmaker, delivered 6% fewer vehicles in the first quarter of 2026 compared with a year earlier. A spokesman for Volkswagen, its parent company, said that Mr Trump's tariffs and a withdrawal of government subsidies for electric vehicles in China were largely responsible for the decline in sales. Volkswagen's shares have fallen by 15% this year so far.

Australia appointed Lieutenant General Susan Coyle as army chief, making her the first woman to lead a branch of the country's **armed forces**. The Australian Defence Force is the subject of a lawsuit that alleges systematic sexual harassment in its ranks. Women make up around 21% of the ADF, more than in other Western armed forces such as Britain and America.

Figure of the day: 60%, the share of young Britons that had some kind of post-secondary qualification in 2024. Read the full article.

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Strait to the brink

The risk of escalation is rising around the Strait of Hormuz. Iran has said any military vessel approaching the waterway would be “dealt with severely”. State media report that Iran is deploying troops to its southern coast, in what appears to be preparation for a potential American invasion. Donald Trump, meanwhile, has announced a blockade of the strait. Central Command, the Pentagon command that runs operations in the Middle East, said it would target all ships entering and exiting Iranian ports, allowing others to pass to and from other Gulf countries.

America’s president is under pressure to reopen the strait and calm energy markets. Rising fuel costs at home have dented his already-low approval ratings. But he seems unsure where things are heading. Asked whether oil and gas prices will fall before midterm elections in November, he replied: “I hope so. I mean, I think so. It could be the same or maybe a little bit higher.”

Photograph: Getty Images

Lebanon’s tight spot

After killing at least 300 people in air strikes on Lebanon on April 8th, Israel has agreed to limit its attacks on Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militia. Mr Trump had urged Israel to be more “low-key”. Beirut, Lebanon’s capital, is reportedly now off the list of targets, but Israel may strike elsewhere. Its troops remain in an 8km-deep strip on the Lebanese side of the border. Meanwhile, Hizbullah continues to attack Israeli towns with missiles and drones.

Israeli and Lebanese diplomats will meet in Washington on April 14th. Lebanon urgently wants to negotiate a ceasefire. Israel will not agree without assurances from the Lebanese government that it will disarm Hizbullah—a task the government would struggle to carry out even if the fighting stopped. Hizbullah and its Iranian patrons have threatened to foment a coup if the government tries. Stuck between Israel and Iran, Lebanon has little room to manoeuvre.

Photograph: Reuters

Goldman Sachs tees off first

Goldman Sachs began earnings season for America's big banks on Monday, publishing its first-quarter results before the opening bell. Revenue rose by 14%, year on year, to $17bn—and net profit by 19% to $5.6bn, beating analysts' expectations. Goldman, Wall Street's biggest dealmaker, benefited from a busy quarter for mergers and acquisitions in which total transactions exceeded $1.2trn—the highest since 2021. Trading-fee income also increased, as market volatility caused by the war in Iran resulted in more activity.

Even so, Goldman's share price fell in pre-market trading. Rising energy prices, sinking valuations for software firms and worries about private credit have hurt banks' valuations in recent weeks. Goldman has not been immune. Investors were looking to this week's earnings for a strong sign that trouble in the market was navigable. They may need more convincing.

Photograph: Reuters

Republicans' tough week in Congress

When America's Senate returns from a two-week break on Monday, Republicans will try to reopen the Department of Homeland Security. That is easier said than done. At almost two months, the partial government shutdown is the longest on record. Democrats refuse to back a funding bill unless it includes reforms to immigration-enforcement agencies. So the Republicans' leaders want to fund that separately, using an arcane procedure called "reconciliation" which requires only a simple majority. That will require clearing two high hurdles: only budgetary measures can be passed by reconciliation, and enough Republicans in the House of Representatives must be persuaded not to scupper the plan.

Iran could provide an unwelcome distraction. Last week Senate Democrats vowed to force a vote on whether to constrain Donald Trump's ability to wage war without congressional approval. The breakdown of peace talks at the weekend will give that renewed urgency. Republican leaders may struggle to walk and chew gum at the same time.

Photograph: Getty Images

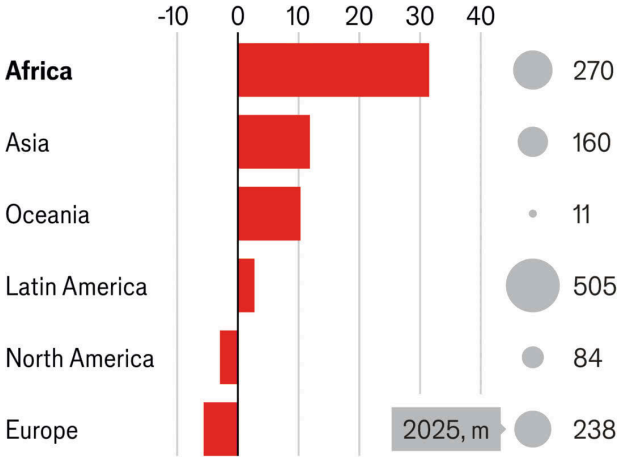
The pope finds a receptive audience in Africa

The papacy of Leo XIV, the first American pontiff, has had a rocky start. His pronouncements on climate change and migration, as well as his criticisms of America's war on Iran, have infuriated MAGA Catholics and Donald Trump—who on Sunday called Leo a "very liberal person" who was "weak" and "terrible".

So Leo's tour of four African countries, which starts on Monday in Algeria, should come as a welcome relief. Catholicism is growing faster in Africa than anywhere else. The continent could be home to as many as half the world's Catholics by 2066. The church is less polarising in Africa than elsewhere. It is widely seen as a champion of democracy, and is relatively untainted by the sexual-abuse scandals which have dogged it in the West. Leo is expected to use his first big overseas trip to deliver a message of peace and concern for the poor. Africa is sure to be receptive, even if America is not.

New Faithful

Catholic population, % change 2015-25



Source: World Christian Database

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which American film maker is known for documentary series on the US civil war, baseball and the Vietnam war?

How can you go out on a limb if you do not know your own tree?

Eudora Welty